

The Great Wooden Horse

The windswept shores of Troy stretch along a bright Aegean sea, where wooden ships with painted eyes lie beached on the long sand and a great city of honey-coloured walls stands proud on the hill above. For a long while two camps, the weary seafarers on the beach and the proud city behind its gates, have been caught in a tired old quarrel that neither truly wants. Across the wine-dark sea lies the long road home, full of wonders: a loyal old hound, a keeper of the winds, and lonely sea-singers on the rocks. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is brave, loyal, and full of ideas. The grandest deeds are done not with spears but with a good idea and a kind heart, and the oldest quarrels often end with a single brave act of friendship.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

For longer than anyone could properly remember, the two camps on the windswept shores of Troy had been caught in a tired old quarrel. Down on the long beach the seafarers lived among their tents and their wooden ships with painted eyes. Up on the hill the proud city stood behind its great honey-coloured walls, with its gates barred fast. Nobody could say how it had started, and the strange thing was that nobody on either side really wanted it any more. Both camps were weary to the bone, and both, in their secret hearts, longed for it simply to end.

Odysseus the Bright called the two of you to his side. He had a short curly beard and a kind, twinkling smile, and he turned a tiny carved horse over in his hands as he spoke. "I have had an idea," he said, "and it is a better one than any shouting across the sand. Let us build a great wooden horse, as tall as a house. But we shall not fill it with soldiers, as the old, sad stories might. We shall fill it with gifts and music and a hand of friendship, and roll it up to the gates as a happy surprise. A kind surprise can end a quarrel that a thousand cross words never could."

Into your hands he pressed three gifts: a basket of honey and figs, a ball of Penelope's thread, and a great spiral conch horn. "Remember," he said, "on these shores we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, loyal to a friend, and full of ideas."



What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Imagination, Courage, or Loyalty?

Stop 1 Building the Horse

The builders had gathered great heaps of smooth wooden planks along the sand, but heaps of wood are not yet a horse. It had to stand tall and strong on its wheels, balanced so it would not wobble or topple, with a neat little door cut into one side.

The carpenters scratched their heads and looked to you. How many planks would each sturdy leg need? How should the curved pieces of the great barrel body be fitted so the whole thing balanced? Penelope's thread was just the tool for measuring a piece before it was cut, and careful counting would tell you exactly how many planks the builders must bring.



How could you build it so it stands straight and steady? Could you measure each piece with the thread? Could you count the planks out together and work out the balance? What is your plan?

When the pieces were measured, counted, and fitted together just so, the great wooden horse rose at last upon its wheels: tall, proud, and steady as the walls themselves. The whole beach broke into a cheer.

Stop 2 Filling It with Friendship

The horse was built, and its little side door stood open like a question. Now came the heart of Odysseus's idea: what should go inside? Not soldiers, and not anything frightening. The entire point was a gift, a surprise so kind that no shut gate could stay shut against it.

You looked over all the lovely things laid out along the sand: the basket of ripe figs and golden honey, garlands of bright flowers gathered from the hillside, and a small drum for making happy music.

★ *Which things would make the kindest surprise? Which gifts whisper, "let us be friends at last"? Choose them together. There is truly no wrong answer here, only warmer ones.*

When you had tucked the figs, the flower garlands, and the little drum safely inside, the great horse seemed to glow with welcome, like a present that can hardly wait to be opened. It was, beyond any doubt, the friendliest horse that the shores of Troy had ever seen.

Stop 3 The Surprise at the Gates

Slowly, and with many willing hands, you rolled the great horse up the long hill to the gates of the city. High on the honey-coloured walls the city folk gathered to watch, wary and weary, and the gates stayed firmly shut. For one long moment your heart thumped in your chest.

But this was never a fight, and the horse was never a trick. It was a gift. All you had to do was show the weary city that it came from friends.

★ *What could you do to show them you come in friendship? You carry the conch horn to sound a warm and welcoming hello across the walls. You could swing open the horse's door and share the sweet figs. What do you try?*

When you lifted the conch horn and sounded its warm, round note, and then opened the little door, out spilled figs and flowers and the merry tap of the drum. The watchful faces on the walls froze, then softened, then broke into astonished smiles. With a great groan of old timber, the gates of the proud city swung open at last.

The Long Quarrel Ends

Down came the city folk from their high walls, and up came the seafarers from the beach, and they met in the middle of the hill, shy and uncertain at first. Then one hand offered a fig to another. Someone tapped the little drum. Somebody laughed, and the laughter spread until the whole hillside rang with it.

Together, side by side, the two camps spread a great feast upon the grass, as though the long quarrel had been no more than a bad dream now happily forgotten. Far out on the gentle, glittering water, Thetis the Sea-Mother raised her face from the waves and smiled to see it. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your courage, with your loyalty to a friend, and above all with your imagination. The oldest quarrel of all had ended, not with spears, but with a single kind surprise. Well done, heroes of the windswept shores of Troy.

The Great Wooden Horse: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle tale with no battle in it at all: the two old camps are simply weary of quarrelling, and the heroes win by ending the quarrel with a kind surprise.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Ship Camp on the beach.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Loyalty** (keeping faith with a friend). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a ball of string for Penelope's thread, a few small treats or tokens for the basket of honey and figs, and any shell or cup for the conch horn. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Imagination and Loyalty together, say, or Courage and Imagination).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. On these shores, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Odysseus the Bright gives you one free hint.
2	You catch your second wind, and take back one energy star.
3	A fair wind, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	Argos the Faithful Hound trots up and wags his tail. All is well.
5	A basket of figs for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A warm sea breeze, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

The wary city at the gates is the "obstacle", but there is no villain here at all, and not one soldier hides inside the horse. The proud city is simply tired of an old quarrel, just as the seafarers are. The tale is won not by beating anyone but by surprising the weary city with friendship: a warm note on the conch horn, an open door, and a shared basket of figs. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Great Wooden Horse: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: Building the Horse (Normal)

The challenge. The great wooden horse must be built tall, strong, and steady on its wheels, with a little door in its side. The players help the carpenters work out how the wooden pieces fit and balance, and how many planks the build will need.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Imagination, Logic, and a little Spatial thinking and Maths. The bright move is to use **Penelope's thread** to measure a piece before it is cut, and to count the planks together so each leg matches and the body balances. Sorting the pieces by shape, or laying out a simple plan before building, works just as well. Settling on any sensible, balanced plan passes the stop.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have a friendly carpenter hold up two planks and ask, "Which of these is longer, do you think?", or let them spend an energy star to "measure twice and cut once". Counting out loud together always gets there. Any steady plan raises the horse and tops up an energy star.

Stop 2: Filling It with Friendship (Easy)

The challenge. The horse is built and its door stands open. The players choose what to put inside. The whole idea is a kind surprise, so the answer is never soldiers and never anything frightening, only friendly things.

Intended solution. This is a gentle Social-emotional and Logic moment. Any warm, welcoming choice works: the **basket of honey and figs** to share, garlands of bright **flowers**, and a **little drum** for happy music. Ask the children which gifts say "let us be friends", and let them explain why. Naming any kind gift, and saying why it is kind, passes the stop.

Fallback. If a child suggests something fierce, gently wonder aloud together, "How would the city folk feel if they opened the door and found that? What would make them smile instead?" Steer warmly towards the figs, the flowers, and the drum. Choosing any kind thing is a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Surprise at the Gates (Normal)

The challenge. The heroes roll the horse up to the city gates, which stay shut. The watchful folk on the walls look wary and weary. The players may feel this is a standoff. It is not. It is a gift waiting to be opened.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Courage and Social-emotional warmth. The city is not an enemy, only tired and unsure. Any genuine, friendly gesture works: sounding the **conch horn** as a warm hello, opening the horse's door, sharing the **figs**, calling up a kind word, or beating the little drum. When the surprise of friendship lands, the great gates swing open. Showing the city any clear sign of friendship passes the stop.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or imagine the gates will never open, have a single curious child appear at the top of the wall and call down, "Is that... for us?" The smallest kindness, a wave, a fig held up, a soft note on the horn, melts the wariness and the gates begin to open.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser, and there never was a soldier in the horse. When the surprise of friendship works, the proud city opens its gates, the two camps spread a feast together on

the hillside, and **Thetis the Sea-Mother** smiles from the calm water. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, loyal to a friend, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

Content licence: CC BY-SA 4.0 (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/>)

Version 3.4, updated 2026-06-05, en-GB



Scan for the latest version

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.